



Parameters & Beyond

[KEYWORDS: PARAMETERS, LINGUISTIC UNIVERSALS, OPTIMALITY THEORY]

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PREFATORY MATTERS

- Syntax, or as a matter of fact, any other core area of Linguistics, posits theory independent of the typology of languages.
- If rules were to be formed based on the perusal of only one language, violations of those rules in languages of different typology would be certain.
- This necessitates the need for typology independent rules in Syntax which essentially deals with word order.
- The method that is appropriated to generalise rules and their broader implications will be discussed here.

PARAMETERS

- Universal grammar provides children, during language acquisition, with a decision space of binary choices. Based on the language the child is learning, the choice is flipped between on and off.
- These different configuration of parameters allow for different variants to exist.
- The concept of parameters is leveraged to posit general rules such that they remain inviolable across typological variations (mostly).
- However, does this Principle and Parameter approach solve the problem of rule incongruity flawlessly ?

PARAMETERS : Illustration (i)

LANGUAGE :	ENGLISH	JAPANESE
Sentence: Gloss:	Kumiko read the book N/A	Kumiko-ga hon-o yonda Kumiko-ga hon-o yon-da Kumiko-NOM book-ACC read-PST
X-bar representation :	$X' \rightarrow X(WP)$ Of the two choices available, an English speaker chooses the configuration in which the complement follows the verb : SVO	$X' \rightarrow (WP)X$ Of the two choices available, a Japanese speaker chooses the configuration in which the verb follows its complement : SVO

PARAMETERS : Illustration (ii)

LANGUAGE :	ENGLISH	JAPANESE
Sentence: Gloss:	Kumiko read the book yesterday N/A	Kumiko-ga kino hon-o yonda Kumiko-ga kino hon-o yon-da Kumiko-NOM yesterday book-ACC read-PST
X-bar representation :	$X' \rightarrow (ZP)X' / X' \rightarrow X'(ZP)$ Adjunct comes on either sides	$X' \rightarrow (ZP)X'$ Japanese is verb-final, which means the only licensed formation requires the adjunct to precede the intermediate projection that gives rise to the zero-level head

PRINCIPLES

- As opposed to parameters, which are modifiable, there are certain rules which are universal across languages.
- Violations of these rules is unlicensed irrespective of typology.
- An example of a linguistic universal would be Sonority Sequencing Principle.
- In Syntax, the hierarchy of x-bar can be considered universal
$$X' \rightarrow X(WP) \text{ or } X' \rightarrow (WP)X \quad \dots\dots\dots (1)$$
$$*X' \rightarrow X(ZP) \text{ or } *X' \rightarrow (ZP)X \quad \dots\dots\dots (2)$$
- Irrespective of typology (2) is unlicensed.

Issues with P&P

- P&P, in its current form, propounded by Chomsky, views parameters as binary switches that once turned off renders it completely unavailable to speakers of that language
- However, as observed in the adjunct rule of English, (ZP) before and after X' is licensed.
- If P&P were to be followed staunchly, either one of those options would be unlicensed for English users.
- P&P has no way to represent a principle being satisfied by one grammatical sentence and violated by another equally grammatical sentence in the same language

Optimality Theory

- Optimality theory, postulated by Alan Prince and Paul Smolensky, neither considers rules to be inviolable, or set binary parameters. Rather they present violable constraints arranged rank wise.
- OT consists of GEN/CON/EVAL
- GEN by default supports X`bar rules
- We can essentially arrange constraints rank wise, such that adhoc rules are not needed to explain why two variants exist concurrently in a language.
- This could technically deal with languages that have free ordering despite having a dominating typology like Malayalam.

Optimality Theory – Illustration

Candidate	STAY	MIN-PROJ	COMP-FINAL	ALIGN-FOC
☞ a. njan ayale konnu (SOV, no movement)				
b. njan konnu ayale (V-medial, base)			*!	
c. ayale konnu njan (OVS, FocP movement)	*!		*	
d. konnu njan ayale (V-initial, V-to-C)	*!			

All four candidates are technically allowed in Malayalam, this is purely to show why the first two are more optimal as opposed to the latter.

References

- 1) *Carnie, Andrew. Syntax: A Generative Introduction. John Wiley and Sons, 2013.*
- 2) *Legendre, Géraldine. (2001). An introduction to optimality theory in syntax. Optimality-Theoretic Syntax.*
- 3) *David Adger. (2003) Core Syntax. Oxford University Press.*